The spec is not the source of truth.

What shipping a Russian/Uzbek water-delivery app taught me about operations vs. plans.

10 slides · swipe

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The field never matched the form.

Incomplete addresses. Partial phone numbers. Russian and Uzbek mixed mid-sentence. Couriers rewriting the route hourly because customers changed their minds.

The form says required.
The street says whatever.

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The failure shapes that actually arrived.

01 Missing street — landmark instead

02 Half a phone number: 'call when close'

03 Apartment number scribbled as a note

04 Russian for the order, Uzbek for the route

05 Dispatch changed by phone, mid-route

None of this fits the spec's dropdowns.

How we adapted instead of arguing.

01 Made input optional — humans cope better than forms

↓

02 Added a free-text notes field — used constantly

↓

03 Dispatchers got full edit rights, not read-only views

↓

04 The app asks instead of blocking

Software that refuses reality loses to people with phones.

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The real lesson in one line.

Every field your software demands is a fight your users will lose somewhere.

Design for the messy middle — not the form template.

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Two products live here.

SPEC

What we designed

validated address
full phone
structured flow

REALITY

What we shipped

optional everything
free notes
dispatcher override

The spec describes the office. The app must serve the street.

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Where automation actually helped.

Order triage, driver assignment, status pings — boring, repetitive, deterministic. Everything fuzzy went to a human with a full screen and full rights.

Automate the boring.
Respect the ambiguous.

What to audit in your next release.

Walk every 'required' field and ask: what does the user do when they can't fill it honestly? Their answer is your next bug report, written in advance.

**Every required field
is a support ticket waiting.**

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The override is the feature.

Ops people don't rebel against software — they rebel against software that treats them as an error case. Give them the keys and they'll forgive the rest.

Design the escape hatch before the happy path.

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SAFALIFE · KEEP THIS · 10/10

Save this for your next ops review.

If your product works only when the data is perfect, it doesn't work — it just hasn't met your users yet.

Save for later review

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